

others) and configure it to use Gmail using the settings provided at this link <http://dgit.in/GKYkAw>. Once all your email has been downloaded (this may take a while), simply export it (from your desktop client) to your favorite location and format.

Now that you've gathered all your data on your local system, let's explore how to make backup copies for it. Apart from hardware backups, there are two ways to back up your data: 1) an entire byte-by-byte disk image 2) an incremental copy of a folder/partition/drive and update it with only the changes made since the last backup. The first method is more thorough but requires considerable time and storage space.

Incremental backup

Most software offer a GUI for "Rsync", a command line utility. Rsync computes the changes made and only then updates them on the destination. This is extremely useful if you're backing up huge archives which only change slightly or are backing up over the network. Grsync is a popular frontend which works on Linux, Solaris, Windows, Mac OS X and even Maemo.

Image-based backup

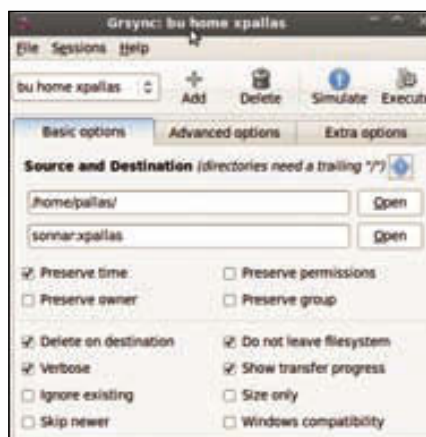
There are many software available to do this task. The most popular paid option for a long while was Norton Ghost. True Image by Acronis (USD 50 for 1 PC license) is also a good option. Perhaps the best free alternatives are Clonezilla (<http://www.clonezilla.org/>) and DriveImage XML (<http://www.runtime.org/driveimage-xml.htm>). CloneZilla is extremely capable, has a live version and an SE version where you can back up upto 40+ computers over a network simultaneously and manage them with ease.

Now that you have a copy of your data, the question is what's the best way to store it for maximum life and safety. Typically archival formats like DVDs/Blu-Rays provide a good solution as you can break up your data into multiple discs and if one gets damaged, the other can still be used. For incremental backups, hard drives provide a good option as the data needs to be frequently

updated. For critical data of low volume, SSDs provide long-term safety and usability due to lack of moving parts. Since cost is a concern here, these are feasible only for low volume of data. You can also back up entire TBs of data online if you're willing. Don't worry about internet bandwidth as most services provide the option of you mailing in your physical hard drive to them (eg. <http://aws.amazon.com/importexport/>).

RAID 1

RAID stands for Redundant Array of Inexpensive Disks and provides a simple and cost-effective method for home backups providing high reliability.



Grsync: One tool to rule them all

Of the many configurations available, right from RAID 0 to RAID 6, a good compromise for a home user wishing to back up data would be the RAID 1 configuration. Here two identical disks are used and the data is automatically mirrored across both, so whenever one disk fails it can be replaced by another without any loss of data. It can be implemented via hardware as a dedicated RAID controller (Many motherboards have a built-in option) or it can be implemented via a software driver. Typically a hardware implementation is recommended.

For software raid, you can go to Control panel > System management > Computer management > Disk management. Now select "dynamic and mirror". More info here: <http://dgit.in/GLwlnH>



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